Notes on Lamps

Gas lamps arrived in London in 1807, when Pall Mall was lit for the King's birthday.[1] Within twenty years most streets of the city had them, and the lamplighter became a familiar figure at dusk.[2] Each carried a long pole with a hook for the valve and a small flame at its tip.

The work was steady but poorly paid, and many lamplighters took second jobs in the daytime to make ends meet.

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1 Contemporary accounts call the display astonishing.

2 Some cities kept them until the 1970s.

Electric light changed everything. By 1900 the arc lamp was common in city centres, and the old gas mantles slowly went dark one street at a time.[3] A few were kept for their charm.

3 A handful still burn in Westminster today.